

# Planning and research

IT IS ESSENTIAL TO PLAN A PIECE OF WRITING.

Good writers always plan their work—on paper rather than in their heads. Planning helps a writer generate ideas, organize them into a clear structure, and avoid leaving anything out.

## SEE ALSO

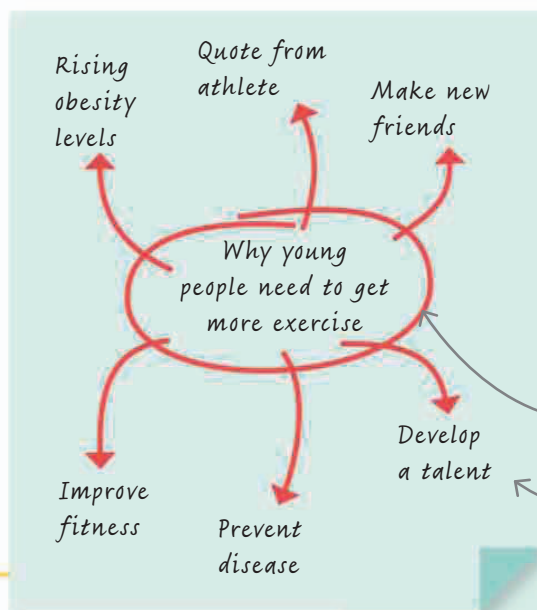
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## First scribbles

The best way to start planning a project is to jot down any relevant ideas, words, and phrases. One method is to use a mind map. At this stage in the planning process, it is useful to think of as many relevant ideas as possible—they can be cut down later.

### ▷ Map out ideas

A mind map is a visual method of writing down notes. The free structure of a mind map can make it a very effective way to generate ideas. However, a simple list is also fine.



- Use **official** or well-known publications or websites for research to ensure that the information is **accurate**.
- Try to **cross-reference** any facts or statistics with another source for accuracy.
- Keep a file called “Bibliography” open whenever working on a project and **regularly update** it.

The idea for the piece of writing goes in the middle.

Ideas are written around the edge.

## Research

It's important to research a piece of writing in order to gain a good overall understanding of a topic, and to gather specific examples, quotations, or statistics. Sources for research include books, websites, and newspapers. To avoid plagiarism (copying someone else's work), always rephrase the sentences.

### ▷ Neat notes

Notes should be neat, organized, and as detailed as possible. Disorganized or incomplete notes will hinder the writing process, and the information may have to be found again.

Write down the source for each statistic, quotation, and fact.

At a later stage, color code each note to show which paragraph it will be used in.

Put quotation marks around quotations now to avoid plagiarism later.

**Worldwide obesity** has more than doubled since 1980.

(World Health Organization Report, 2012)

**“Physical inactivity** is an independent risk factor for coronary heart disease—in other words, if you don't exercise, you dramatically increase your risk of dying from a heart attack when you're older.”

Dr. John Hobbs